

The First Conference on Iran-Africa Cultural Dialogues

Cultural Tolerance and Peaceful Coexistence

By

G. Ojwang' Ochieng'

Kenyatta University (Department of Philosophy and Religious Studies)

ABSTRACT

Culture is the arts, customs, and habits that characterize a particular society or nation, and culture is an important component in a society's conception and implementation of development agenda. The core to any culture, is its value system, which ought to both inform and act as an evaluation tool for any development strategies that are put in place. We observe, however, that contemporary Africa's and Iran's development talks and strategies are mainly based on an uncritical acceptance of foreign culture and values which stress "economic gain" and "speed ups" more than sustainability. The discussion on Iran and Africa concerning the crisis of development has not factored in the role that Persian and African cultures and ethics can play in remedying the situation. We are therefore forced to think in Western cultures which are universalized and the ones which have held the fabric of these two cultures have been pushed to the sideline and termed backward. This paper has analyzed the issues affecting Iranian and African cultures, which are sidelined and rendered redundant while trying to push for western cultures to the globalized village. The processes of globalization have proved to be having damaging side-effects, which include the exploitative realities of free trade, globalization's preferential treatment of the corporate West, environmental degradation, and cultural erosion with its excessive individualism which are not part and parcel of the Persian and African cultures. Undoubtedly, western-led processes of globalization are built upon the efficacy of free trade and the primacy of the individual, but this overt emphasis on the individual is viewed by many in the Muslim world as coming at the expense of the sacrosanct communities. Thus the "me' culture," which "fuels the engine of globalization," is creating harmful "contaminants" that are adversely affecting traditional societies, by encouraging self-centeredness in the pursuit of economic goals and pleasure. Globalization destroys the capacity to empathize with others which is fundamental and encouraged by both African and Persian cultures. The Persian and African societies, which are mainly community centered, see the world in a different light, viewing excessive concern with the self as both a deviation and a sign of social breakdown. Hence, Mbiti's ideology, "I am" because "we are", since in African cultures an individual cannot live in isolation. Thus cultural relativism perpetuated by the west is wrong and having a universal culture is impossible. This paper therefore advocates for cultural respect, tolerance and peaceful co-existence in the world composed of thousands of cultures, instead of cultural relativism which is being spearheaded by the west.

Key words: *African, Culture, Co-existence, Globalization, Persian, Relativism, and Tolerance*